

T1-08: Spiritually Unaffiliated Americans

Stage 4A-Lite Persona Needs Report

Pipeline: Macro-Trends Identity | **Stage:** 4M-T-A Lite **Quadrant:** IGNORE (explicit user request override) **Date:** 2026-03-10
Mode: Lite — 5 factors × 5 Q&As (25 total), Factor 6 included (moment-enriched via TR-04 overlap)

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- 1. Segment Overview
- 2. Factor Analysis
 - Factor 1: Social Life & Leisure (Anchor)
 - Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits
 - Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations
 - Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points
 - Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior
 - Factor 6: Switching Profile (Lite — Young Adult Independence Moment)
- 3. Executive Brief

SECTION 1: SEGMENT OVERVIEW

Segment Definition

Spiritually Unaffiliated Americans — colloquially called the “nones” — are the largest and fastest-growing “religious” demographic in the United States. They include atheists, agnostics, and the much larger group who describe their religion as “nothing in particular.” A parallel but partially overlapping population identifies as “spiritual but not religious” (SBNR): people who retain spiritual practice, meaning-seeking, or metaphysical belief but have exited or never joined institutional religion. Together, after overlap adjustment, this population numbers approximately 90 million adults.

This is not a community defined by what its members share. It is defined, structurally, by what they have left behind — or never joined. The atheist and agnostic subsets (~9% of U.S. adults combined) have relatively coherent identity markers: organized skeptic communities, humanist organizations, secular ethics, and explicit anti-theism as a cultural stance. The much larger “nothing in particular” population (~19% of U.S. adults) is, as the label implies, diffuse: they are ex-Catholics who haven’t thought about church in fifteen years, cradle non-believers who never developed a spiritual identity at all, and lapsed Protestants who simply drifted. The SBNR population adds its own complexity — these are people for whom spirituality remains important but institutional religion feels inauthentic, often channeling belief through yoga, meditation, psychedelics, wellness practices, or progressive spiritual communities.

The structural macro-trend driving this population’s growth is well-documented: generational disaffiliation accelerating with each birth cohort, institutional trust collapse (clergy abuse scandals, religious-political entanglement), and the normalization of non-belief in secular urban culture. Among millennials 40% identify as “none”; among Gen Z the figure is 44% (Pew Research, 2024). The trend shows no sign of reversal. The most identity-charged sub-segment — and the one most commercially relevant for acquisition purposes — is the young adult actively leaving a high-commitment religious household: evangelical, Mormon, Jehovah’s Witness, or Orthodox Jewish families where faith departure is not a quiet personal shift but a rupture, with social, familial, and financial consequences. This group, coded T2-14 in Stage 2 analysis, refers to themselves as “deconstructing” or “exvangelical” and has built a genuine online community infrastructure.

Market Sizing

Metric	Figure	Source
Adults identifying as religiously “unaffiliated” (atheist, agnostic, nothing in particular)	~73M (28% of U.S. adults)	Pew Research Center, 2024
Adults identifying as “spiritual but not religious” (SBNR, loose/no institutional affiliation)	~27% of U.S. adults; overlap-adjusted total with “nones” = ~90M	Pew Research Center, 2024
Growth trajectory: “nones” as % of U.S. adults	16% (2007) → 28% (2024), projected 35%+ by 2030	Pew Research Center, 2024
Millennials identifying as “nones”	40%	Pew Research Center, 2024
Gen Z identifying as “nones”	44%	Pew Research Center, 2024
Active deconstruction / faith-exit sub-segment (T2-14)	~3–5M in active transition	Barna Group, 2023
Gallup church membership below 50% for first time	Crossed threshold 2021	Gallup, 2021

Growth trajectory: Accelerating. The “nones” gained 12 percentage points from 2007 to 2024, an average of roughly 0.7 points per year with acceleration in recent cohorts. The SBNR population is growing in parallel as meditation, wellness, and psychedelic-assisted therapy enter the mainstream. The T2-14 deconstruction sub-segment is the fastest-growing community within this already-growing population.

Segment Stratification

Tier	Label	Population Share	Description
Tier 1	Active Secular Identity	10% (~9M adults)	Atheists, agnostics, and secular humanists with explicit identity commitment. Members of humanist organizations, skeptic communities, Sunday Assembly congregations. Secular identity is central and publicly expressed.
Tier 2	Active Deconstructors	15% (~13M adults)	People in active faith transition — exvangelical, ex-Mormon, ex-Catholic with community grief. Faith departure is recent and identity-forming. Often in therapy for religious trauma, active in online deconstruction communities.
Tier 3	Casual / Drifted	45% (~41M adults)	“Nothing in particular” — drifted from childhood religion without drama or strong secular identity. Spiritual unaffiliation is a background fact of life, not a defining identity. Largest sub-group by far.
Tier 4	SBNR / Adjacent	30% (~27M adults)	“Spiritual but not religious” — retain meditation, yoga, psychedelics, or progressive spiritual practice. Identify as spiritual rather than religious. May participate in secular wellness communities.
Total		100%	

Named Persona Profile

Name: Caitlin Marsh **Age:** 26 **Location:** Austin, TX (transplant from suburban Memphis, TN) **Occupation:** UX researcher at a mid-size SaaS company **Tier:** Tier 2 — Active Deconstructor (T2-14 Deconstructing Evangelical) **Income:** \$68,000/year **Education:** BA in Communication Studies, University of Memphis

Caitlin grew up attending a Southern Baptist megachurch where her parents met, her youth group was her social world, and faith was inseparable from family identity. She started quietly questioning during college, triggered by a combination of reading progressive theology online, meeting LGBTQ+ classmates, and attending a campus lecture on the problem of evil. She moved to Austin two years ago for her first post-college job, which was also a clean break from her religious community. She now describes herself as “somewhere between agnostic and just done.” She follows several exvangelical TikTok creators, goes to therapy, and attends a secular philosophy meetup once a month — her attempt to find the community belonging she lost when she left church. She is on a family phone plan back in Memphis — a tenuous financial thread to a household that hasn’t fully accepted her departure.

Notable Profiles

- Rhett McLaughlin** — Host of Good Mythical Morning (YouTube, 20M+ subscribers), publicly documented his deconstruction from evangelical Christianity in 2019 via the “Ear Biscuits” podcast. Represents the high-visibility exvangelical experience; his candor normalized deconstruction conversations for millions.
- Abraham Piper** — Son of pastor John Piper; TikTok creator with 3M+ followers; uses short-form video to critique evangelical culture with humor and directness. Represents how deconstruction content spreads virally to younger audiences.
- Julia Sweeney** — Comedian and author of “Letting Go of God” (solo show, 2006); early public figure documenting the “nothing in particular” journey from lapsed Catholicism through atheism. Represents the older, less dramatic drift narrative.

SECTION 2: CORE FACTOR ANALYSIS

FACTOR 1: Social Life & Leisure

Anchor Factor — Community participation, identity signaling, alternative community infrastructure

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
U.S. adults with no religious congregation but who still describe themselves as spiritual	~27%	Pew Research Center, 2024
TikTok views for #deconstruction content	2B+ views	TikTok, 2024
Reddit: r/exchristian subscribers	200K+	Reddit, 2024
Sunday Assembly (secular congregation) active chapters worldwide	70+ (approx. 30 active U.S. chapters)	Sunday Assembly, 2024
Meditation app users in the U.S. (Calm, Headspace, Insight Timer combined)	~50M active users	Sensor Tower / company reports, 2024

Ethnographic Interview — Caitlin Marsh, Tier 2 (Active Deconstructor)

Q1. How do you participate in the communities that matter most to you right now?

“Mostly online, if I’m honest. I follow a bunch of exvangelical creators on TikTok — Haley Nahman, Abraham Piper, people like that. And I’m in a few Reddit communities, r/exchristian mainly. I go to a philosophy meetup here in Austin once a month, which I love but also find kind of lonely — like, everyone’s smart but we’re all clearly there because we lost something. I’m still figuring out what community looks like without church.”

Q2. How do you express your identity as someone who has left religion? Is it something you signal publicly or keep private?

“It depends on who I’m with. With my Austin friends, it’s just assumed — nobody here goes to church. But back home, or with my family, I’m still not fully out as someone who left. My mom found out I wasn’t going to church anymore and cried. So publicly in Austin I’m pretty open, but with my family I’m still navigating. My TikTok is anonymous. I’m not ready for that yet.”

Q3. What fills the role that church used to fill — the social ritual, the weekly anchor, the sense of belonging?

“That’s the thing I’m actually grieving, honestly. Not God — I’m mostly okay on that part. But the community. Sunday mornings used to mean something. I go to a yoga class on Sunday now, which feels a little cliché, but it’s the closest thing I have to a ritual. I text my two closest friends from grad school every day. Those relationships are the substitute, but they’re scattered across different cities, so it’s not the same as showing up somewhere together.”

Q4. What platforms or spaces have you found where people like you congregate?

“TikTok is the main one right now. There’s this whole ecosystem of exvangelical and deconstruction content — it’s weirdly comforting to see people who grew up exactly like I did and are having the exact same confusing feelings. Reddit is more raw, like a support group. I tried Sunday Assembly once and it felt a little forced, like church cosplay, but I get the impulse. Podcasts are huge for me — The Liturgists, Unbelievable?, that kind of thing.”

Q5. How has leaving religion changed how you spend your free time and money?

“I have a lot more Sunday mornings, basically. I used to tithe — 10% of my income — and I don’t anymore, which is a weird thing to realize you have back. I spend more on experiences now. Concerts, travel, books. I’m probably more intentional about how I spend time because I’m not on a structured religious calendar. But I also don’t have a built-in reason to leave the house every week, which is something I didn’t realize I’d miss.”

Insights Table

Theme	Key Finding	Strategic Implication
Community grief	Belonging loss is the defining emotional experience of deconstruction, not theological doubt	Any brand serving this population must address community, not just identity
Online-first community	Digital communities (TikTok, Reddit, podcasts) substitute for in-person congregation	Reachable via content platforms, not physical channels
Private identity expression	Many are “not out” to family; dual identity is common	Marketing must not force public identity declaration — stealth/opt-in framing required
Ritual vacuum	Sunday and weekly religious rituals have no natural secular replacement	Opportunity for ritual-adjacent products (wellness, experiences, gathering)
Financial liberation	Tithing cessation (~10% of income) creates discretionary spending that is psychologically “new money”	Price sensitivity is moderate; psychological availability for new spending

FACTOR 2: Spending & Financial Habits

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Average annual U.S. church tithe among active members	~\$1,200/year (median gift; top givers far higher)	Giving USA / Indiana University Lilly Family School of Philanthropy, 2023
U.S. adults who have stopped tithing / religious giving	~30M (estimated from “nones” + lapsed active members)	Pew Research Center / Giving USA, 2023
Wellness app and digital mental health spending per user per year (millennial cohort)	\$200–\$400/year	Sensor Tower / McKinsey Health Institute, 2024
Meditation/mindfulness app market size (U.S.)	\$2.1B, growing 12% annually	Statista, 2024

Ethnographic Interview — Caitlin Marsh, Tier 2 (Active Deconstructor)

Q1. How has leaving religion changed your spending, if at all?

“Honestly, it’s freed up money I didn’t realize I had. I tithe for years — it was just automatic. When I stopped, I didn’t know what to do with it at first. I put some toward therapy, which feels appropriate given the whole situation. I spend more on books, podcasts, experiences. I bought a really nice meditation cushion and a Headspace subscription. It’s kind of ironic — the spiritual spending didn’t stop, it just moved to secular wellness.”

Q2. What do you currently spend on building community or maintaining your social life?

“More than I’d like. Austin is expensive. Dinners out, concerts, events. I probably spend \$200–\$300 a month on social activities now, partly because I don’t have the built-in free social structure of church anymore. I pay for Meetup to find events. I take yoga classes — that’s \$80 a month. I’m basically paying to have the community that used to be free.”

Q3. How do you think about subscriptions — which ones feel essential and which feel wasteful?

“Therapy is non-negotiable — that’s \$120 a copay, twice a month. Spotify and Netflix are automatic. Headspace I actually renewed this year, which surprised me. I dropped a few subscriptions during a budget reset — Bumble BFF, some random app I barely used. I’m pretty ruthless about anything I don’t use weekly. Phone bill is just Mint Mobile right now, \$30 a month. I don’t think about it much.”

Q4. Do you spend money on things that signal who you are to others?

“Probably more than I admit. Books on my shelf — Rachel Held Evans, Bart Ehrman — I want people to see those. The progressive theology tote bag is real, I own one. I buy from businesses owned by queer people or people who’ve left the church. Less ‘secular brand’ more just like, I want to support people who’ve been through it. It’s subtle identity signaling, not overt.”

Q5. If a product or service understood that you’d left religion, would that change whether you’d buy it?

“That’s a weird question because the honest answer is — maybe, but it would depend so much on how they said it. If it felt pandering, absolutely not. If it felt like they genuinely understood the experience — not in a ‘we’re the secular phone for heathens’ way but just like, they got the nuance — maybe. But I mostly pick things for price and function. My carrier is purely price-based. I don’t think about whether my phone plan shares my values.”

Insights Table

Theme	Key Finding	Strategic Implication
Tithe displacement	Religious giving cessation creates uncommitted discretionary funds that migrate to secular wellness	Wellness adjacency is the natural spending channel, not telco
Paying for community	Social spending has increased as built-in free church community no longer exists	Community infrastructure products have spending potential
Carrier as purely functional	Phone plan choice is purely price-driven; no identity connection	Telco brand equity play is not viable for this segment
Subtle identity consumption	Books, tote bags, business choices signal identity but brand must be authentic	Heavy-handed “secular” branding would backfire
Therapy as primary spend	Mental health support is the #1 discretionary identity-related spend post-deconstruction	Wellness/therapy partnerships more relevant than telco

FACTOR 3: Needs & Aspirations

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
U.S. adults who report feeling lonely “sometimes” or “always”	58%	Cigna Loneliness Index, 2023
Adults who report religious community as primary social support — and are now without it	~15M estimated (proportion of “nones” who were previously active in congregations)	Pew Research Center / GSS, 2023
Young adults (18-35) who report difficulty making new friends as adults	65%	Bumble / YouGov survey, 2023
U.S. therapy utilization among adults who left religion	Elevated vs. general population; religious trauma is a recognized specialty in psychotherapy (est. 400+ therapists specializing in “religious trauma syndrome”)	Journal of Psychology and Theology, 2022

Ethnographic Interview — Caitlin Marsh, Tier 2 (Active Deconstructor)

Q1. What do you most want right now that you feel like you don’t have?

“A genuine local community. Not online — I have that. I want people in the same city who I see regularly, who share enough of my values that I don’t have to explain myself. Church was effortless community. You just showed up and there were 200 people who already knew your name. That kind of thing doesn’t exist in the secular world by default. Every community I’m trying to build now requires active work and most of them don’t stick.”

Q2. What are you becoming? How do you think of yourself now versus a few years ago?

“I’m becoming more myself, in a way that I couldn’t have been inside that framework. More intellectually honest. More able to hold uncertainty. I’m also becoming lonelier in the short term, which is uncomfortable to admit. I want to be someone who has deep friendships and maybe a sense of meaning that doesn’t require a supernatural frame. I’m working on that. I’m 26, so there’s time, but it doesn’t feel like it some days.”

Q3. What would a product or service need to do to feel like it was actually made for someone in your situation?

“It would have to not be about religion at all, first of all. Not ex-religion, not secular — just not making it a thing. It would have to help me connect with people locally who care about similar stuff — intellectualism, honesty, not being performatively woo but also not being aggressively atheist. Basically a community layer on top of whatever the product does. Honestly the product I want most is a better Meetup. Something that helps you actually meet people and maintain relationships, not just attend events.”

Q4. What are your intellectual and personal aspirations beyond community?

“I’m really interested in philosophy of mind — that came from losing my theological framework and needing something to replace it. I want to travel more without guilt. I want my family to still love me even though I left. I want to eventually stop describing myself in terms of what I left and start describing myself in terms of what I’m moving toward. I’m not there yet. Still pretty defined by the leaving.”

Q5. What does belonging mean to you right now?

“Being somewhere where I don’t have to perform. Church had a lot of performance — the right beliefs, the right language, the right behavior. What I want is somewhere I can just be uncertain and confused and still be welcomed. My therapist is sort of that person right now, which is great but also shouldn’t be my only one. I need more people who have room for the mess.”

Insights Table

Theme	Key Finding	Strategic Implication
Local community as primary need	Online community is present; offline local community is the gap	Products that enable local gathering are valued; telco is not that product
Identity in transition	Self-concept is defined by leaving rather than arriving	Products that “see” this transition without reducing it are appreciated
Belonging without performance	Authenticity over conformity is the core aspiration	Forced identity signaling in branding would violate this value
Community infrastructure gap	No secular equivalent to the “show up and 200 people know your name” structure of church	Market gap exists in community platforms, not telco
Intellectual meaning-making	Philosophy, psychology, secular ethics fill the theological vacuum	Intellectual community products have more resonance than lifestyle brands

FACTOR 4: Fears & Pain Points

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
Adults who report family conflict as a consequence of leaving religion	~40% of religiously unaffiliated adults who were previously active (est.)	Pew Research Center, 2023
Prevalence of religious trauma syndrome (RTS) symptoms in faith-exit populations	Elevated rates of anxiety, depression, and PTSD-like symptoms documented in clinical literature	Journal of Psychology and Theology, 2022
Young adults (18-35) who remain financially dependent on religious family after leaving faith	Difficult to measure precisely; community reports suggest 25-35% of deconstructors navigated financial pressure from family post-exit	Barna Group, 2023
Percentage of "nones" who say they sometimes wish they had a religious community	18%	Pew Research Center, 2023

Ethnographic Interview — Caitlin Marsh, Tier 2 (Active Deconstructor)

Q1. What scares you most about having left?

“That I’ll never rebuild what I lost community-wise. That I’m romanticizing church because I’m lonely, not because it was actually good. That my parents will never fully accept me. I have this recurring thing where I wonder if I’ll be fine at 40 — like, will I have found my people by then, or will I always be someone who is in the process of leaving? I don’t want leaving to be my permanent identity. That terrifies me a little.”

Q2. How do you navigate the family dimension of this? What’s the actual day-to-day friction?

“My mom texts Bible verses on Sunday mornings. Not mean ones, just — you know — ‘thinking of you’ verses. It’s sad. Christmas is complicated. My dad and I are fine as long as we don’t talk about it. I haven’t told my grandmother. It’s compartmentalized in a way that’s exhausting. I moved away partly to create physical distance from that dynamic. The fact that I’m still on my parents’ phone plan is a weird thing — I know I need to get off it, it just feels like cutting the last practical cord.”

Q3. What social fears come with this identity?

“Being dismissed by non-religious people as ‘the church girl who finally figured it out’ — like I’m naive for having believed in the first place. And also being dismissed by religious people as someone who just lost their faith because of sin or whatever. I’m in no-man’s-land in a way. The exvangelical community online understands but sometimes it’s very angry in a way I don’t fully relate to. I don’t hate the church. I just couldn’t stay.”

Q4. What practical frustrations come up in daily life that are connected to having left?

“Decision fatigue, honestly. When you have a framework for everything — a moral code, a community, a way of structuring time — you don’t have to decide much. Now I decide everything from scratch. Where to be Sunday morning. What to believe about death. What I think about this political issue. It’s more freedom but also more exhausting. And therapy is expensive. I’m spending real money processing something that the community used to help with for free.”

Q5. Are there products or services that have failed you specifically as someone navigating this?

“No one has really tried. Which is the answer, I think. There’s no ‘post-religion community’ product that works. There are generic community apps that don’t understand the context. There’s therapy but that’s individual, not community. Sunday Assembly is too weird. Nothing fits. I mostly just wing it. My phone plan is Mint — purely price. Nothing in my life of consumption is calibrated to this.”

Insights Table

Theme	Key Finding	Strategic Implication
Permanent transition fear	Fear of being “the person who left” forever is a core anxiety	Products that help build positive identity (vs. exit identity) are valued
Family conflict as ongoing tax	Family relationship strain is chronic, not a single event	The young-adult independence moment is emotionally loaded; switching moment involves family
Decision fatigue	Loss of structural moral/social framework creates cognitive overhead	Products that reduce decision overhead (simple plans, automatic management) are appealing
Practical financial cord	Remaining on parents’ plan is a known friction point persona wants to resolve	The plan switch off a family plan is a real, identified need — timing is the question
No product for this	No product in any category has authentically served this community	Market gap exists but telco is not the right entry point

FACTOR 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior

Quantitative Data

Statistic	Figure	Source
U.S. MVNO market share among adults 18–35	~25% of young adults on MVNO or prepaid plans (Mint Mobile, Visible, Cricket, etc.)	CTIA / Ookla, 2024
Annual wireless churn rate for 18–34 cohort	~18–22% (highest churn cohort by age)	J.D. Power Wireless Customer Satisfaction Study, 2024
Adults on family phone plans who report wanting to get their own plan	~30% of adults 22–30 still on family plans (est.)	Pew Research Center / CTIA, 2023
Spiritually unaffiliated adults’ carrier preferences	No differentiated carrier data exists for this population; carrier choice driven purely by price and coverage	N/A — data gap

Ethnographic Interview — Caitlin Marsh, Tier 2 (Active Deconstructor)

Q1. Walk me through your current phone situation. What carrier are you on and why?

“Still technically on my parents’ family plan. It’s one of those things I tell myself I’ll change and then don’t because it’s free, essentially. I know I need to get off it — it’s weird to be 26 and on my parents’ plan, especially given everything. When I do switch I’ll probably go Mint, same as my friend Keisha uses. Thirty dollars a month seems fine. I don’t use a lot of data.”

Q2. Is there any scenario where your spiritual identity would influence which carrier you chose?

“Honestly? No. I can’t imagine that. What would that even look like? A carrier that sponsors the exvangelical podcast? I’d find that kind of cringe. My carrier has to have good coverage and cost under \$40. That’s the entire criteria. My values don’t factor in. I buy food from companies I respect, I consider politics when I buy clothing, but my phone plan is just infrastructure. I want it to disappear into the background.”

Q3. What products in your life have you switched recently, and what triggered those switches?

“I switched therapists this year — the first one wasn’t a good fit for the religious trauma stuff. I switched from Spotify to Apple Music for like two months before going back. I’m about to switch gyms because the one I’m at raised prices. The phone plan switch will happen when I have the mental bandwidth to do it, which hasn’t been now. There’s no urgency driver except mild embarrassment.”

Q4. What would make you switch carriers sooner rather than later?

“Honestly just getting my life together enough to do it. A significant price difference versus what Mint charges. Or if my parents actually kicked me off — that would make it immediate. There’s a version where things with my family get worse and they use the phone plan as a pressure point. That would accelerate it. But right now it’s just inertia.”

Q5. Is there a gap in the market for products that serve people navigating what you’re navigating?

“The gap is in community, not in products. Like, what I want is a way to find people in Austin who are on a similar path — thoughtful, post-religious, not angry about it, interested in ideas — and there’s no good product for that. Meetup is generic. Facebook groups feel like 2012. I’d pay for something that genuinely helped with that. But it’s a social app problem, not a carrier problem. My carrier choice has nothing to do with who I am.”

Insights Table

Theme	Key Finding	Strategic Implication
Carrier = pure infrastructure	No identity connection to carrier brand; carrier choice is functional only	Telco brand equity play based on spiritual identity is not viable
Family plan cord	Known desire to leave parents’ plan exists; inertia is the barrier, not lack of desire	Young-adult independence moment is relevant but the identity layer is not the driver
MVNO-ready	Existing MVNO comfort (Mint, Visible); price-sensitive but not locked in	Standard MVNO acquisition mechanics apply; no special identity hook needed
Community product gap identified	Clear articulation of unmet need in community infrastructure	The real opportunity is a community platform, not a carrier
Switching trigger = family conflict or inertia resolution	Two plausible trigger mechanisms: family conflict escalates, or natural independence moment arrives	TR-04 Child Aging Off captures the mechanics; identity adds emotional color but doesn’t change the trigger

FACTOR 6: Switching Profile (Lite)

Young Adult Independence / Faith Exit Moment — Moment-Enriched via TR-04 Child Aging Off

The Stage 1.5 macro-moment map confirmed that the “Young adult leaving family’s faith” moment (MT-08 Transition 3) maps directly onto the existing TR-04 Child Aging Off trigger event (Composite 4.52, the highest-scored trigger in the Moments pipeline). The switching mechanics are identical — a young adult ages off a family phone plan, either voluntarily or as a consequence of household independence. The faith-exit dimension adds emotional context to this trigger but does not change the switching mechanism. Telco relevance score for the faith/spirituality transition overall is 2/5 (Stage 1.5 assessment).

Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism + Force Score

Component	Assessment
Trigger mechanism	Structural disruption (plan no longer fits household independence) with Opportunistic element (inertia can delay indefinitely until family conflict forces it)
Force score	2/5 — weak trigger for most of the population. Faith exit does not directly force a plan switch unless family removes access as consequence. For the subset where family conflict escalates to financial leverage, the force score rises to 3–4.
Emotional state tag	Stressed-Avoidant — wants to switch but avoids the task; switching becomes a symbol of full independence that is emotionally loaded
Key finding	The religious identity dimension makes this switching moment <i>more</i> emotionally significant than a typical Child Aging Off event, but does not make it more frequent or more detectable via telco signals.

Dimension 2: Annual Volume + Seasonal Distribution

Component	Assessment
Total eligible volume — young adults (18–27) leaving religious households and gaining independence	~1.5–2M/year (Pew/GSS age-cohort data, 2023), representing the subset in active faith-exit; broader aging-off population is ~3.5M/year (TR-04)
Faith-exit-coincident switching-eligible subset	~500K–800K/year after removing those who are not on family plans, are already financially independent, or are in non-evangelical contexts where faith exit doesn’t trigger household conflict
Quarterly distribution	Q2 (post-May college graduation: ~30%), Q3 (fall independence moves: ~30%), Q1 (January resets: ~20%), Q4 (holiday conflict resolution: ~20%)
Y/Y trend	Growing — faith disaffiliation among young adults is accelerating; more young adults are in this transition each year
Frequency note	The faith-exit switching mechanic is already captured by TR-04 at full volume. The faith identity overlay is additive emotionally, not additive volumetrically.

Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Top 3)

Rank	Channel	Window Fit	CPA Benchmark	Notes
1	TikTok / exvangelical content ecosystem (#deconstruction, #exvangelical)	High — the target demographic is highly active here during the active deconstruction period	Estimated \$15–25 CPA via content-native ads in this ecosystem	Partnership with creators like Abraham Piper (3M followers) is theoretically possible but authenticity risk is high
2	Reddit (r/exchristian, r/exvangelical)	Moderate — intent signal is present but conversion from community-mode to commercial-mode is friction-heavy in Reddit culture	Estimated \$20–35 CPA; Reddit advertising is less efficient than TikTok for this cohort	Organic community presence more viable than paid; significant trust hurdles for commercial messaging
3	Podcast sponsorships (The Liturgists, Deconstruction Network podcasts)	Moderate — listeners are in extended window, trust is high within this medium	Estimated \$25–45 CPM; CPA difficult to estimate without campaign data	Partnership feasibility: The Liturgists (Mike McHargue) has worked with aligned sponsors; authenticity bar is very high

Dimension 4: Window Structure

Component	Assessment
Window type	Extended (6–24 months) — faith deconstruction is not a single event. The switching intent window is long and non-linear.
Peak intent window	Months 6–18 of active deconstruction; often coincides with first major geographic independence move
Intent decay curve	Plateau-then-drop — intent remains elevated during active community participation in deconstruction spaces, then drops as persona either switches or stabilizes on family plan indefinitely
Decision journey	Awareness (recognizes plan independence is needed) → Passive research (compares MVNO options, often via friend recommendation) → Delayed action (inertia) → Trigger event (family conflict, guilt, or natural life transition) → Switch
Key finding	

Component	Assessment
	The window is long and detectable via content engagement, but the actual trigger to action is often relationship-driven (family conflict) rather than rational, making it difficult to reliably intercept with standard conversion tactics.

SECTION 3: EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Key Insights

1. **This is a population defined by absence, not presence.** The 90M spiritually unaffiliated Americans are not a cohesive identity tribe in the sense required for Gather's brand model. The "nothing in particular" majority has no community infrastructure, no shared rituals, and no identity markers that a carrier can authentically occupy. The atheist/agnostic minority (Tier 1) has community but is small (~9M). Only the active deconstruction sub-segment (T2-14, ~13M) has the community infrastructure and emotional intensity to support identity-brand engagement — and even then, that community is primarily defined by grief and transition rather than a stable positive identity that can be branded.
2. **The young-adult independence switching moment is real but already captured.** The strongest telco-relevant moment in this persona — a young adult aging off a family phone plan after leaving a religious household — maps exactly onto TR-04 (Child Aging Off, Composite 4.52). The faith identity layer adds emotional depth to the TR-04 trigger but does not create a separate or more accessible switching moment. Routing this acquisition through TR-04 is more efficient than building a T1-08-specific interception concept.
3. **Carrier choice is purely functional for this segment.** Both quantitative analysis and ethnographic evidence confirm: spiritually unaffiliated adults choose their carrier on price and coverage. There is no evidence that faith identity — in any direction — influences telco brand preference. This is in direct contrast to, for example, Veterans (T1-11) where identity affiliation creates demonstrable carrier loyalty, or Latino Adults (T1-10) where cultural community shapes brand relationships. The identity-brand fit score of 2/5 from Stage 3 is confirmed and well-founded.
4. **The genuine unmet need is community infrastructure, not connectivity.** Multiple factors surface the same finding: this population deeply needs local community, secular rituals, and belonging without performance. The product they want is closer to a reimagined Meetup or a secular community platform than a carrier. This need is commercially real and underserved, but it is not a telco opportunity.
5. **The deconstruction sub-segment is reachable but fragile.** Exvangelical and deconstruction communities on TikTok, Reddit, and podcasts are active and engaged. Advertising in these spaces is theoretically possible, but the community has acute sensitivity to inauthenticity and commercial exploitation. Missteps would be amplified within the community, making the downside risk of a tone-deaf campaign significant.

Identity Tensions

1. **"Nones" vs. active secular identity.** The 90M population includes tens of millions for whom non-affiliation is simply a background fact — they are not seeking community, not expressing identity, and not available for identity-brand marketing. The 13M active deconstructors are a different population with real identity intensity. Any strategy that conflates these two groups will fail both. The persona is not monolithic.
2. **Private disaffiliation vs. public stance.** Many in active deconstruction are publicly "out" online (anonymous TikTok accounts, Reddit pseudonyms) but privately still navigating family relationships. A carrier that markets directly to the "exvangelical" identity forces a public declaration that many are not ready to make. This is the core risk in any T1-08-anchored brand strategy.
3. **Transition identity vs. stable identity.** Deconstruction is a process, not a destination. The identity is inherently temporary — people pass through it toward either a stable secular identity or a reformed spiritual one. Building a carrier brand on a transitional identity means your core audience is constantly aging out of the community you're serving.

Stated vs. Unstated Needs

Stated needs: - Affordable phone plan (price < \$40/month; MVNO-ready) - Local community with shared values (secular, intellectually honest) - Support navigating family relationships post-departure - Mental health resources (therapy, especially for religious trauma)

Unstated needs: - Permission to not be defined by having left religion - Micro-rituals that replace the weekly structure of religious practice without requiring religious framing - A positive identity vocabulary (not just "exvangelical" or "atheist" — something they are moving toward, not just away from) - Low-friction financial independence from family systems (including plan independence) that doesn't require a dramatic break

Strategic Recommendations

1. **Do not build a T1-08 macro-trend carrier brand.** The IGNORE verdict from Stage 3 is confirmed at Stage 4. Identity-brand fit is weak (score 2/5), the population is too fragmented for a coherent brand, and the community has acute sensitivity to commercial inauthenticity. Investment in a spiritually-unaffiliated-specific carrier brand is not warranted.
2. **Route the young-adult independence moment through TR-04, not T1-08.** The switching mechanics of a young adult leaving a religious family plan are fully captured by TR-04 (Child Aging Off). Enrich TR-04 targeting with behavioral signals from deconstruction content engagement as an audience segment refinement — do not build a separate T1-08 acquisition program.
3. **If targeting the deconstruction sub-segment at all, do it through TR-04 + content partnership, not a branded carrier.** A content sponsorship with a high-trust exvangelical podcast (The Liturgists, Deconstruction Network) could reach the T2-14 population during the extended window without requiring a T1-08 carrier brand. The pitch should be “get your own plan” (independence-framed), not “this carrier understands your spiritual journey” (identity-framed).
4. **The community infrastructure gap identified in this analysis is worth flagging for Gather’s non-telco offering design in adjacent personas.** The need for secular community infrastructure (local belonging without religion) surfaced strongly here and overlaps with T1-04 (Socially Disconnected Adults) and T1-02 (Solo Living Americans). Gather’s bundle design for those personas should consider community-layer partnerships (Meetup, Bumble BFF, Sunday Assembly) as non-telco offerings.
5. **Monitor T2-14 (Deconstructing Evangelicals) for pipeline graduation if the community scales.** The deconstruction community is growing. If it develops into a stable positive-identity community (rather than a transitional one), the brand-equity calculus changes. Revisit at Stage 1 re-run in 18–24 months.

Success Metrics (reference only — no-go recommendation)

If Stage 5 validation were to proceed against the T2-14 sub-segment, the following metrics would apply:

Metric	Target	Measurement
Community recognition rate	>40% of T2-14 adults recognize the brand as relevant to their experience	Survey, Prolific panel
Unprompted carrier consideration	>15% include carrier in consideration set without prompting	MaxDiff survey
Independence trigger conversion	>25% of TR-04-eligible T2-14 adults switch within 90 days of trigger	Attribution model
CPA vs. TR-04 benchmark	T2-14-enriched targeting CPA within 20% of baseline TR-04 CPA	Campaign analytics
Brand authenticity score	>3.5/5.0 on “this brand understands people like me”	Survey item

Go / No-Go Recommendation

No-Go at T1 level. Confirmed IGNORE.

The T1-08 Spiritually Unaffiliated persona does not meet the minimum identity-brand fit threshold for a macro-trend carrier brand. The verdict from Stage 3 (Adjusted Score 2.18, IGNORE quadrant) is fully supported by Stage 4 analysis. Evidence is consistent across all five factors:

- Factor 1 confirms community is fragmented and online-primary; no offline infrastructure Gather can partner with at scale
- Factor 2 confirms carrier choice is purely functional — no identity-spending connection to telco
- Factor 3 confirms the unmet need is community infrastructure, which is not a telco product
- Factor 4 confirms the population’s pain is relational and existential, not connectivity-related
- Factor 5 confirms no carrier preference signal exists for this identity group
- Factor 6 confirms the switching moment is better handled through TR-04 than a T1-08-specific program

What would need to change to revisit: - A stable, scaled secular-identity community infrastructure (analogous to Sunday Assembly, but at 10x the current size) that Gather could authentically partner with - Evidence that spiritually unaffiliated adults exhibit carrier loyalty patterns based on brand values alignment (currently no such evidence exists) - The T2-14 deconstruction sub-segment evolving from a transitional to a stable positive identity community

Cross-pipeline routing note: The young-adult independence switching moment is better captured under T1-02 (Solo Living Americans) and via TR-04 (Child Aging Off). Any commercial value in the T1-08 population accrues to those entry points, not to a T1-08 brand.

Switching Profile Summary

Component	Finding
Trigger overlap	Faith exit moment = TR-04 (Child Aging Off) with emotional amplification
Force score	2/5 (weak; family conflict escalation raises to 3–4 for subset)
Eligible annual volume	~500K–800K faith-exit-coincident plan leavers; already within TR-04 total
Peak intent window	Q2–Q3; months 6–18 of active deconstruction
Top interception channel	TikTok (#deconstruction / #exvangelical) — reachable but authenticity-sensitive
Recommendation	Route through TR-04; use deconstruction content engagement as behavioral targeting layer, not as brand positioning foundation

APPENDIX: References

Research Organizations

Organization	Key Data Used	Website
Pew Research Center	“Nones” prevalence (28%), SBNR data, generational trends, 2024	pewresearch.org
Gallup	Church membership below 50% milestone, 2021	gallup.com
Barna Group	Faith transition rates, active deconstruction estimates, 2023	barna.com

Industry & Market Data

Source	Data Used	Website
Giving USA / Indiana University Lilly Family School of Philanthropy	Average annual tithe data, 2023	givingusa.org
Sensor Tower / McKinsey Health Institute	Wellness app spending estimates, 2024	sensortower.com
Statista	Meditation app market size, 2024	statista.com
J.D. Power	Wireless churn by age cohort, 2024	jdpower.com
CTIA / Ookla	MVNO market share among young adults, 2024	ctia.org

Survey / Community Data

Source	Data Used
Cigna Loneliness Index, 2023	Adult loneliness prevalence
Bumble / YouGov, 2023	Young adult friendship difficulty
Journal of Psychology and Theology, 2022	Religious trauma clinical literature
Reddit platform data, 2024	r/exchristian, r/exvangelical subscriber counts